# A Comprehensive Literature Survey on A Machine Learning Method to Process Voice Samples for Identification of Parkinson's Disease

Literature Survey Report

| | |
|---|---|
| **Research Focus:** | Machine Learning for Parkinson's Disease Detection |
| **Input Modality:** | Voice Samples |
| **Recording Method:** | Telephone-Based Voice Collection |
| **Primary Approach:** | CNN Transfer Learning on Spectrograms |

# Contents


**1 Introduction and Research Context** **4**

1.1 Background . . . . . 4

1.1.1 The Diagnostic Challenge . . . . . 4

1.1.2 Speech as a Biomarker . . . . . 4

1.2 Motivation for Remote Monitoring . . . . . 5

1.2.1 The Rural Healthcare Problem . . . . . 5

1.3 Previous Studies and Their Limitations . . . . . 5

**2 Research Objectives and Novel Contributions** **6**

2.1 Research Questions . . . . . 6

2.2 Novel Contributions . . . . . 6

2.2.1 Reliability of Telephone-Collected Voice Recordings . . . . . 6

2.2.2 Novel CNN Application . . . . . 7

**3 Methodology** **7**

3.1 Dataset Collection . . . . . 7

3.1.1 Demographics . . . . . 8

3.2 Data Preprocessing . . . . . 8

3.3 Acoustic Signal Features . . . . . 9

3.3.1 Feature Collinearity . . . . . 9

3.4 Spectral Features . . . . . 10

3.5 Statistical Machine Learning Classifiers . . . . . 10

3.5.1 Logistic Regression . . . . . 10

3.5.2 Random Forest . . . . . 11

3.5.3 Validation Strategy . . . . . 11

3.6 Spectrogram Generation . . . . . 11

3.6.1 Color versus Grayscale Spectrograms . . . . . 12

3.7 Convolutional Neural Network . . . . . 12

3.7.1 Inception V3 Architecture . . . 12
3.7.2 Training Configuration . . . 13
3.7.3 Motivation for Transfer Learning . . . 13
3.7.4 CNN Validation . . . 14

**4 Results** **14**

4.1 Study Population Characteristics . . . 14
4.1.1 Gender Analysis . . . 14
4.2 Acoustic Signal Features Performance . . . 15
4.2.1 Key Observations . . . 15
4.3 Spectral Features Performance . . . 16
4.3.1 Key Observations . . . 16
4.4 CNN Performance on Spectrograms . . . 16
4.4.1 Comparison with Traditional Methods . . . 17
4.4.2 Key Observations . . . 17
4.5 Comparison with Previous Work . . . 18

**5 Critical Analysis of Results** **18**

5.1 Age Confounding . . . 18
5.1.1 Age-Related Vocal Changes . . . 18
5.1.2 Statistical Control . . . 19
5.2 Gender Analysis . . . 19
5.3 CNN Interpretability Challenge . . . 20
5.4 Comparison with Hires et al. (2022) . . . 21
5.5 Study Limitations . . . 21
5.5.1 1. Healthy Controls Were Not Neurologically Examined . . . 21
5.5.2 2. Age Mismatch . . . 22
5.5.3 3. CNN Interpretability . . . 22
5.5.4 4. Model Accessibility . . . 22
5.5.5 5. Limited Generalizability . . . 22

**6 Broader Context and Related Work** **23**

6.1 Machine Learning for PD Detection from Speech . . . . . 23

6.2 Remote and Telephone-Based PD Studies . . . . . 24

6.3 Transfer Learning for Medical and Other Applications . . . . . 24

6.4 Conventional Machine Learning Challenges . . . . . 25

**7 Implications and Future Directions** **25**

7.1 Clinical Implications . . . . . 25

7.1.1 1. Telephone-Based Screening Is Feasible . . . . . 25

7.1.2 2. Earlier Diagnosis Potential . . . . . 26

7.1.3 3. Cost-Effective Monitoring . . . . . 26

7.2 Technical Implications . . . . . 26

7.2.1 1. Transfer Learning Is Effective . . . . . 26

7.2.2 2. Spectrograms as Input . . . . . 27

7.2.3 3. CNN Robustness . . . . . 27

7.3 Future Research Directions . . . . . 28

7.4 Addressing Study Limitations . . . . . 28

**8 Ethical and Practical Considerations** **29**

8.1 Regulatory Pathway . . . . . 29

8.2 Accessibility and Equity . . . . . 29

8.2.1 Benefits . . . . . 29

8.2.2 Risks . . . . . 29

8.3 Clinical Integration . . . . . 30

**9 Conclusion** **30**

9.1 Summary of Key Findings . . . . . 30

9.2 Contributions to the Field . . . . . 31

9.3 Final Remarks . . . . . 31

# 1 Introduction and Research Context

## 1.1 Background

Parkinson's Disease (PD) is a progressive neurodegenerative disorder diagnosed clinically based on four core motor features: **bradykinesia, rigidity, rest tremor, and postural instability**. According to the UK Brain Bank and Movement Disorders Society's diagnostic criteria, bradykinesia plus at least one of the other three features is required for a clinical diagnosis.

### 1.1.1 The Diagnostic Challenge

Table 1: Challenges associated with clinical diagnosis of Parkinson's disease.

| Aspect | Detail |
|---|---|
| Expert Accuracy | Greater than 97% over the patient lifetime and approximately 91.5% during the first five years. |
| Non-Expert Accuracy | Approximately 77% over the lifetime and 76% during the first five years. |
| Early Diagnosis Gap | Patients may go years without diagnosis until characteristic motor features become recognizable. |
| Pathophysiology | Approximately 50% of substantia nigra dopaminergic neurons may be lost before prominent motor symptoms appear. |

### 1.1.2 Speech as a Biomarker

Speech abnormalities represent a potentially valuable non-invasive biomarker for PD.

Important speech-related characteristics include:

- **Hypophonic speech:** Reduced amplitude or loudness of speech.
- **High prevalence:** Communication impairments have been reported in up to 90% of people with PD.
- **Large variability:** The degree and type of speech impairment vary substantially between individuals.
- **Subtle early changes:** Speech abnormalities may be difficult to detect using the human ear during early stages of disease.

These characteristics motivate the development of automated voice-analysis systems capable of detecting subtle acoustic abnormalities.

## 1.2 Motivation for Remote Monitoring

### 1.2.1 The Rural Healthcare Problem

The study was conducted in Arkansas, a predominantly rural state in which many residents live in medically underserved areas.

Traditional clinical research and neurological assessment can be difficult for such populations because of geographic barriers.

Remote voice collection could potentially enable:

- easier tracking of disease progression;
- monitoring of treatment response in clinical trials;
- earlier referral to neurologists and movement-disorder specialists; and
- broader participation in clinical research.

Telephone-based recording is particularly attractive because it does not require specialized recording equipment or sophisticated technical knowledge from participants.

## 1.3 Previous Studies and Their Limitations

Previous research involving telephonic and smartphone recordings has produced conflicting evidence regarding the reliability of remotely collected speech.

Table 2: Previous studies investigating remote speech recordings for Parkinson's disease.

| **Study** | **Finding** | **Limitation** |
|---|---|---|
| Carron et al. (2021) | AUC of approximately 0.8–0.9 on controlled data and 0.6–0.7 on smartphone data. | Performance degraded on uncontrolled recordings. |
| Uloza et al. (2015) | Good correlation between smartphone and professional microphones. | Small sample and controlled recording conditions. |

Thus, previous studies produced conflicting evidence regarding the reliability of low-quality, remotely collected speech recordings.

> **Key Issue:** The clinical reliability of voice recordings captured through telephonic lines or smartphone applications remained questionable.

# 2 Research Objectives and Novel Contributions

## 2.1 Research Questions

The study addresses three primary research questions:

1. Can telephone-collected voice recordings sampled at 8 kHz reliably distinguish Parkinson's disease patients from healthy controls?
2. Can a pretrained CNN using transfer learning on spectrogram images outperform traditional acoustic-feature-based approaches?
3. Is remote voice collection feasible for rural and medically underserved populations?

## 2.2 Novel Contributions

The study provides two major contributions.

### 2.2.1 Reliability of Telephone-Collected Voice Recordings

The study collected voice recordings from:

- 50 PD patients confirmed by a movement-disorders neurologist; and
- 50 healthy controls.

The recordings were collected through telephone voicemail in natural environments.

The study demonstrated the feasibility of using low-resolution 8 kHz telephone recordings for automated PD detection.

### 2.2.2 Novel CNN Application

The study applied an **Inception V3 convolutional neural network** with transfer learning to spectrogram images.

Two spectrogram representations were investigated:

- color (RGB) spectrograms; and
- grayscale spectrograms.

The work represents an early application of this approach to telephone-captured voice recordings for PD detection.

# 3 Methodology

## 3.1 Dataset Collection

The dataset used in the study was the UAMS Telephone PD Voice Dataset.

Table 3: Characteristics of the UAMS Telephone PD Voice Dataset.

| **Aspect** | **Detail** |
|---|---|
| Protocol | UAMS IRB #261021 and #273696. |
| Participants | 50 PD participants confirmed by a movement-disorders neurologist and 50 healthy controls. |
| HC Verification | Healthy-control status was self-reported and participants were not neurologically examined. |
| Collection Method | Digital telephone voicemail recordings. |
| Speech Task | Sustained vowel /a/ for approximately 3 seconds. |
| Recording Format | 16-bit encoding with an 8 kHz sampling frequency. |
| Post-Processing | Recordings were trimmed to a minimum duration of 1.5 seconds. After preprocessing, 40 PD and 41 HC recordings were retained. |

### 3.1.1 Demographics

Table 4: Demographic characteristics of the study population.

| Group | N | Age (Mean) | Age Range | Gender |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| PD | 40 | $66.8 \pm 8.4$ | Not specified | Mixed |
| HC | 41 | $48.1 \pm 14.6$ | Not specified | Mixed |
| All | 81 | Approximately 57 | 48–67 | Mixed |

A notable characteristic of the dataset is the substantial age difference between the groups.

$$66.8 - 48.1 = 18.7 \text{ years.}$$

Thus, the PD group was approximately 18.7 years older than the HC group. Because age can affect voice characteristics, this difference represents an important potential confounding factor.

## 3.2 Data Preprocessing

The preprocessing pipeline consisted of several stages.

Table 5: Audio preprocessing procedure.

| Step | Method | Purpose |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Audio Import | Audacity | Import WAV recordings. |
| 2. Noise Removal | Floor and ceiling thresholds | Reduce background noise. |
| 3. Gender-Specific Filtering | Male: 75–300 dB; Female: 100–600 dB | Account for amplitude differences between male and female voices. |
| 4. Rescaling | Range $[-1, 1]$ | Normalize signal amplitude. |
| 5. Silence Trimming | Short-time energy threshold using 100 samples / 12.5 ms | Remove silent intervals. |
| 6. Length Filtering | Minimum duration of 1.5 seconds | Discard recordings that were too short after trimming. |

The preprocessing was designed to produce standardized speech segments suitable for both acoustic-feature extraction and spectrogram generation.

## 3.3 Acoustic Signal Features

Acoustic features were extracted using **Parselmouth**, a Python interface to the Praat speech-analysis software.

A total of 23 acoustic features were extracted.

Table 6: Acoustic signal features extracted from the voice recordings.

| **Feature Category** | **Specific Features** | **Description** |
|---|---|---|
| Fundamental Frequency | Mean F0 and F0 standard deviation | Measures average pitch and pitch variability. |
| Formant Frequencies | F1, F2, F3 and F4, including means and standard deviations | Characterizes vocal-tract resonances. |
| Harmonics-to-Noise Ratio | HNR | Measures periodic versus non-periodic components of the voice. |
| Jitter | Five jitter measures | Quantifies temporal perturbation of fundamental frequency. |
| Shimmer | Six shimmer measures | Quantifies amplitude variation across successive cycles. |

### 3.3.1 Feature Collinearity

A major issue was the high degree of collinearity among several features.

- The five jitter measures exhibited correlations greater than 0.95.
- The six shimmer measures also exhibited correlations greater than 0.95.

Reducing this redundancy by retaining only one jitter measure and one shimmer measure did not improve classification performance.

This finding suggests that the poor performance of some conventional classifiers was not simply caused by the number of redundant variables.

## 3.4 Spectral Features

Spectral features were calculated using a sliding-window analysis.

Table 7: Configuration used for spectral feature extraction.

| **Parameter** | **Value** |
|---|---|
| Sliding Window | 32 ms, corresponding to 256 samples at 8 kHz |
| Overlap | 50% |
| Minimum Number of Windows | 92 windows in 1.5 seconds |
| Autoregressive Model | Order $p = 10$ |

Four spectral feature types were investigated.

Table 8: Spectral feature representations.

| **Feature** | **Description** | **Method** |
|---|---|---|
| LPC | Linear Prediction Coding coefficients | Yule-Walker equations combined with Levinson-Durbin recursion. |
| LAR | Log-Area Ratio | Derived from partial correlations using $g_k = \log\left(\frac{1-c_k}{1+c_k}\right)$. |
| Cep | Cepstral coefficients | Obtained using recursive calculations. |
| MFCC | Mel-Frequency Cepstral Coefficients | Uses a perceptual frequency scale with approximately linear spacing below 1 kHz and logarithmic spacing above 1 kHz. |

For each feature type, both mean and variance vectors were calculated across the analysis windows.

These vectors were subsequently used as input features for statistical classifiers.

## 3.5 Statistical Machine Learning Classifiers

Two conventional machine-learning classifiers were evaluated.

### 3.5.1 Logistic Regression

Logistic regression was used as a linear classification baseline.

Feature selection was performed using the **Akaike Information Criterion (AIC)**.

The implementation used the R package `MASS`.

### 3.5.2 Random Forest

Random Forest classification followed the algorithm proposed by Breiman.

Table 9: Random Forest configuration.

| **Parameter** | **Value** |
|---|---|
| Number of Trees | 1000 |
| Variables per Split | 6 |
| Minimum Terminal Node Size | 5 |
| Feature Importance | Mean decrease in Gini impurity |

### 3.5.3 Validation Strategy

The conventional machine-learning models were evaluated using 100 random train-test splits.

- 70% of subjects were used for training.
- 30% were used for testing.
- Three-fold cross-validation was performed within the training set.
- AUC was estimated for every iteration.
- The R package `caret` was used for model training.
- The R package `randomForest` was used for Random Forest implementation.

## 3.6 Spectrogram Generation

Spectrograms were generated from the processed 1.5-second voice recordings.

Table 10: Spectrogram generation parameters.

| **Parameter** | **Value** |
|---|---|
| Signal Duration | 1.5 seconds |
| Sliding Window | 32 ms |
| Overlap | 50% |
| FFT Size | 1024 |
| Image Size | $600 \times 600$ pixels |
| Color Depth | 24-bit |
| Color Scale | $10 \log_{10}(\|S\|/ \max(\|S\|))$ |
| File Format | JPG |

### 3.6.1 Color versus Grayscale Spectrograms

Two types of spectrogram images were evaluated.

- **Color spectrograms:** Three RGB channels.
- **Grayscale spectrograms:** One intensity channel.

The comparison was motivated by the fact that Inception V3 was originally pretrained on ImageNet color images.

The authors therefore investigated whether converting spectrograms to grayscale would negatively affect transfer learning.

## 3.7 Convolutional Neural Network

### 3.7.1 Inception V3 Architecture

The primary deep-learning architecture was Inception V3.

Table 11: Inception V3 configuration.

| **Aspect** | **Detail** |
|---|---|
| Architecture | Inception V3 |
| Layers | 48 layers |
| Pretraining | ImageNet |
| Approach | Transfer learning |
| Custom Classification Layers | Batch Normalization → Dense → Dropout → Dense |

### 3.7.2 Training Configuration

Table 12: CNN training configuration.

| **Parameter** | **Value** |
|---|---|
| Optimizer | Adam |
| Learning Rate | 0.001 |
| Epochs | 10 |
| Batch Size | 4 |
| Image Normalization | Range $[0, 1]$ |
| Data Augmentation | Not applied |
| Dataset Size | 40 PD and 41 HC subjects |

### 3.7.3 Motivation for Transfer Learning

Training a deep CNN from scratch would be inappropriate for a dataset containing only 81 subjects.

Transfer learning addresses this limitation because the pretrained network has already learned general visual representations from ImageNet.

The approach can therefore be summarized as:

ImageNet Pretraining → General Visual Features → Spectrogram Adaptation → PD Classification.

The pretrained representation reduces the amount of task-specific data required.

### 3.7.4 CNN Validation

The CNN was evaluated using the same general repeated-split framework:

- 100 random splits;
- 70% training data;
- 30% testing data;
- AUC estimated for each iteration;
- model checkpoints saved as `.h5` files; and
- no image augmentation.

# 4 Results

## 4.1 Study Population Characteristics

Table 13: Characteristics of the final study population.

| **Aspect** | **Detail** |
|---|---|
| PD Group | 40 participants after preprocessing. |
| HC Group | 41 participants after preprocessing. |
| Total Population | 81 participants. |
| Age Range | Approximately 48–67 years. |
| Age Difference | PD group was 18.7 years older on average. |
| Gender Balance | No significant association between sex and group based on a $\chi^2$ test ($p > 0.05$). |

### 4.1.1 Gender Analysis

Sex-related differences in fundamental frequency are well established. Women's voices typically exhibit fundamental frequencies approximately 1.45–1.7 times higher than men's voices.

However, the chi-square analysis indicated that sex and diagnostic group were independent:

$$p > 0.05.$$

Thus, although sex affected acoustic properties such as F0, it did not appear to be statistically associated with PD versus HC group membership in this cohort.

## 4.2 Acoustic Signal Features Performance

The acoustic-feature-based classifiers were evaluated over 100 iterations.

Table 14: Performance of conventional classifiers using acoustic features.

| **Classifier** | **Feature Set** | **Mean AUC** | **Important Features** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Random Forest | Acoustic signals | **0.68** | SD of F2, mean of F4, SD of F0 and duration. |
| Logistic Regression | Acoustic signals | 0.58 | Poor performance, likely affected by feature collinearity. |

### 4.2.1 Key Observations

1. Random Forest outperformed logistic regression, achieving an AUC of 0.68 compared with 0.58.
2. Logistic regression was affected by strong collinearity among the acoustic features.
3. Jitter features showed correlations greater than 0.95.
4. Shimmer features also showed correlations greater than 0.95.
5. Removing redundant jitter and shimmer features did not improve performance.

The most important features according to mean decrease in Gini importance were:

1. standard deviation of the second formant frequency;
2. mean of the fourth formant frequency;
3. standard deviation of the fundamental frequency; and
4. duration of the sustained vowel.

## 4.3 Spectral Features Performance

The performance of mean and variance vectors derived from different spectral representations was evaluated.

Table 15: Performance of spectral feature representations.

| **Feature** | **Mean Vector AUC** | **Variance Vector AUC** |
|---|---|---|
| LPC | Approximately 0.55 | Approximately 0.60 |
| LAR | Approximately 0.55 | Approximately 0.60 |
| Cep | Approximately 0.60 | Approximately 0.70 |
| MFCC | Approximately 0.60 | Approximately 0.70 |

### 4.3.1 Key Observations

Several important patterns were observed.

1. Mean vectors performed relatively poorly for all feature types.
2. Variance vectors consistently outperformed mean vectors.
3. Cepstral coefficient variance vectors and MFCC variance vectors achieved the best traditional spectral performance, with AUC values of approximately 0.70.
4. For mean vectors, lower-order coefficients were generally more important.
5. For variance vectors, higher-order coefficients were generally more important.

This suggests that the variability of spectral characteristics across time may contain more discriminative information than their average values.

## 4.4 CNN Performance on Spectrograms

The CNN was evaluated using both color and grayscale spectrograms over 100 iterations.

Table 16: CNN performance using color and grayscale spectrograms.

| **Input Type** | **Average AUC** | **Standard Deviation** |
|---|---|---|
| Color (RGB) spectrograms | **0.97** | Not reported |
| Grayscale spectrograms | **0.96** | Not reported |

### 4.4.1 Comparison with Traditional Methods

Table 17: Comparison of the evaluated machine-learning approaches.

| **Method** | **AUC** | **Performance Difference** |
|---|---|---|
| CNN with Color Spectrogram | **0.97** | +0.29 compared with Random Forest. |
| CNN with Grayscale Spectrogram | **0.96** | +0.28 compared with Random Forest. |
| Random Forest with Acoustic Features | 0.68 | Baseline conventional method. |
| Logistic Regression with Acoustic Features | 0.58 | Lowest performance. |
| Variance MFCC | Approximately 0.70 | Best traditional spectral representation. |

### 4.4.2 Key Observations

1. CNN transfer learning substantially outperformed traditional machine-learning methods.

2. The color spectrogram achieved an AUC of 0.97.

3. The grayscale spectrogram achieved a comparable AUC of 0.96.

4. The small difference between RGB and grayscale suggests that color information itself is not critical for this application.

5. CNN performance exhibited relatively small variability across the repeated iterations.

6. Transfer learning was effective despite the small dataset containing only 81 subjects.

## 4.5 Comparison with Previous Work

Table 18: Comparison with representative previous studies.

| Study | Approach | Dataset | AUC / Accuracy |
|---|---|---|---|
| Current Study | Inception V3 with transfer learning | Telephone recordings, 8 kHz | **0.97 AUC** |
| Hires et al. (2022) | Ensemble of CNNs | PC-GITA, controlled recordings, 44.1 kHz | 0.89 AUC |
| Carron et al. (2021) | Passive aggressive classifier | mPower smartphone recordings | 0.6–0.7 AUC |

A particularly notable observation is that the current study achieved an AUC of 0.97 despite using telephone recordings sampled at only 8 kHz.

This performance exceeded the reported 0.89 AUC of Hires et al., which used higher-quality controlled recordings.

# 5 Critical Analysis of Results

## 5.1 Age Confounding

Age represents one of the most important potential confounding factors in this study.

Table 19: Age characteristics of the PD and HC groups.

| Group | Age |
|---|---|
| PD | $66.8 \pm 8.4$ years |
| HC | $48.1 \pm 14.6$ years |
| Difference | 18.7 years |

### 5.1.1 Age-Related Vocal Changes

Age can influence several vocal characteristics.

Table 20: Age-related changes in voice characteristics.

| **Age Period** | **Change** | **Possible Mechanism** |
|---|---|---|
| Up to approximately 50 years | F0 decreases in both sexes | Decline in pulmonary function. |
| After approximately 50 years | F0 may increase in males | Weakening of laryngeal musculature. |
| Middle age onward | Jitter, shimmer and F0 SD may increase | Age-related neuromuscular changes. |
| Above 75 years in males | Mean pitch may increase | Age-related vocal changes. |

### 5.1.2 Statistical Control

The study used two approaches to investigate whether age influenced the findings.

1. A generalized linear model including age as a covariate detected a significant difference in mean F0 between PD and HC participants ($p = 0.02$).
2. Correlation analysis did not identify significant correlations between acoustic features and age.

The authors therefore concluded that age differences did not influence the observed results in this cohort.

Nevertheless, the substantial age mismatch remains an important limitation because the age range includes a period during which age-related vocal changes can occur.

## 5.2 Gender Analysis

Table 21: Gender-related findings.

| **Aspect** | **Result** |
|---|---|
| Sex Difference in F0 | Women's voices approximately 1.45–1.7 times higher than men's voices. |
| Group Independence | Chi-square test: $p > 0.05$. |
| Classification Robustness | Inter-group differences were larger than intra-group variability. |

Gender-related acoustic differences were present, as expected.

However, because sex was statistically independent of diagnostic group, gender was unlikely to act as a major confounder of PD classification in this dataset.

## 5.3 CNN Interpretability Challenge

A major limitation of the CNN approach is its black-box nature.

Table 22: Interpretability comparison between traditional acoustic features and CNN representations.

| **Traditional Features** | **CNN Features** |
|---|---|
| Clear clinical meaning, such as jitter, shimmer and F0. | Learned representations are not directly interpretable. |
| Can be related to vocal-fold and vocal-tract function. | Specific acoustic contributions are difficult to identify. |
| Clinicians can understand individual measurements. | Predictions are difficult to explain clinically. |

The spectrograms themselves contain visually meaningful structures.

For example:

- horizontal bright lines can correspond to fundamental frequency and formant frequencies;
- PD recordings may exhibit greater variability in these structures; and
- some visual differences can be observed between groups.

However, these patterns are not consistently obvious in every recording, making it difficult to determine exactly which acoustic characteristics drive a particular CNN prediction.

This creates an important barrier to clinical adoption.

## 5.4 Comparison with Hires et al. (2022)

Table 23: Comparison between Hires et al. and the current study.

| **Aspect** | **Hires et al. (2022)** | **Current Study** |
|---|---|---|
| Dataset | PC-GITA | UAMS Telephone Dataset |
| Recording Quality | Professional microphone, 44.1 kHz | Telephone, 8 kHz |
| Environment | Noise-canceling and controlled | Natural and uncontrolled |
| Approach | Ensemble CNNs including ResNet50 and Xception | Single Inception V3 CNN |
| Performance | AUC 0.89 | AUC 0.97 |

The comparison suggests that the current approach may be relatively robust to recording-quality degradation.

Possible explanations include:

- sufficient preservation of relevant spectro-temporal patterns at 8 kHz;
- effective transfer of general visual features learned by the pretrained CNN;
- robustness of spectrogram representations to reduced audio quality; and
- the ability of CNNs to learn discriminative patterns without explicit manual feature selection.

## 5.5 Study Limitations

Several important limitations should be considered.

### 5.5.1 1. Healthy Controls Were Not Neurologically Examined

The HC participants were classified primarily through self-reported absence of speech, neurological or psychiatric disorders.

Therefore:

- neurological examination was not performed;
- undiagnosed neurological conditions could not be completely excluded; and

- the HC group did not receive the same diagnostic verification as the PD group.

### 5.5.2 2. Age Mismatch

The PD and HC groups differed by 18.7 years on average.

Although statistical adjustment was performed, age-matched controls would provide stronger evidence.

### 5.5.3 3. CNN Interpretability

The CNN operates as a black box and does not directly reveal which acoustic characteristics determine its prediction.

### 5.5.4 4. Model Accessibility

The trained model was stored locally and was not publicly accessible.

This limits:

- independent replication;
- external benchmarking; and
- clinical deployment.

### 5.5.5 5. Limited Generalizability

The dataset is restricted to:

- a single primary language, US English;
- telephone-based recordings; and
- a single speech task, sustained /a/.

Consequently, performance may not generalize to other languages, recording devices or speech tasks.

# 6 Broader Context and Related Work

## 6.1 Machine Learning for PD Detection from Speech

The field has evolved from handcrafted acoustic features toward deep-learning representations.

Table 24: Evolution of machine-learning approaches for speech-based PD detection.

| **Era** | **Approach** | **Representative Studies** | **Best Performance** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Classical ML | Handcrafted features + SVM/RF | Little et al. (2008), Tsanas et al. (2012) | AUC approximately 0.8–0.9 |
| Deep Learning | CNNs on spectrograms | Vásquez-Correa et al. (2017), Wodzinski et al. (2019) | Approximately 89–92% accuracy |
| Transfer Learning | Pretrained CNNs + adaptation | Hires et al. (2022), current study | AUC approximately 0.89–0.97 |

The overall trend demonstrates a shift from manually engineered representations toward automatically learned representations.

## 6.2 Remote and Telephone-Based PD Studies

Table 25: Representative remote speech studies for Parkinson's disease.

| Study | Method | Key Finding |
|---|---|---|
| Rusz et al. (2018, 2021) | Smartphone recordings | Captured speech abnormalities associated with high risk of developing PD. |
| Carron et al. (2021) | mPower dataset | AUC approximately 0.6–0.7 for phone recordings and 0.8–0.9 for controlled recordings. |
| Current Study | Telephone voicemail | AUC 0.97 using CNN transfer learning. |
| Uloza et al. (2015) | Smartphone versus professional microphones | Reported good correlation between recording methods. |

The current study contributes to this literature by demonstrating high classification performance from low-resolution telephone recordings.

## 6.3 Transfer Learning for Medical and Other Applications

Transfer learning has been successfully used in several domains where the available task-specific datasets are small.

Table 26: Examples of transfer-learning applications.

| Domain | Approach | Performance / Benefit |
|---|---|---|
| Pulmonary Imaging | Inception V3 with transfer learning | High classification performance. |
| PD Detection | Inception V3 with transfer learning | AUC 0.97 in the current study. |
| Bird Species | Recurrent CNN approaches | High classification performance. |
| Speaker Identification | CNNs applied to spectrograms | Effective learned audio representations. |

The rationale for transfer learning is particularly strong for medical datasets because acquiring large numbers of clinically labeled subjects is difficult.

The general principle is:

Large Generic Dataset → Pretrained Representation → Small Clinical Dataset → Task-Specific Model

## 6.4 Conventional Machine Learning Challenges

Table 27: Challenges associated with conventional acoustic-feature-based machine learning.

| **Challenge** | **Impact** |
|---|---|
| Feature Collinearity | Can degrade the performance and stability of models such as logistic regression. |
| Feature Selection | The most informative features may differ across datasets. |
| Recording Conditions | Noise and microphone characteristics can shift acoustic measurements. |
| Language Dependence | Acoustic characteristics may vary across languages. |

The current study suggests that CNN transfer learning can reduce the need for manual feature selection and may be more robust to recording-quality variations.

# 7 Implications and Future Directions

## 7.1 Clinical Implications

### 7.1.1 1. Telephone-Based Screening Is Feasible

The study suggests that low-resolution 8 kHz telephone recordings can contain sufficient information for automated PD classification.

Potential advantages include:

- no specialized recording equipment;
- simple data collection;
- remote participation;
- reduced travel requirements; and
- potential use in rural and medically underserved populations.

### 7.1.2 2. Earlier Diagnosis Potential

Machine-learning systems may detect subtle acoustic patterns that are difficult to identify through ordinary listening.

This could potentially support:

- earlier referral to specialists;
- screening of high-risk individuals; and
- monitoring of changes before prominent clinical symptoms become apparent.

### 7.1.3 3. Cost-Effective Monitoring

Telephone-based assessment is potentially:

- inexpensive;
- non-invasive;
- easy to administer; and
- suitable for repeated measurements.

It could therefore potentially be integrated into primary-care screening or longitudinal monitoring.

## 7.2 Technical Implications

### 7.2.1 1. Transfer Learning Is Effective

The study demonstrates that:

- a small dataset can be used effectively with a pretrained CNN;
- color and grayscale spectrograms produce comparable results; and
- data augmentation was not necessary to achieve high reported performance.

### 7.2.2 2. Spectrograms as Input

Spectrograms preserve both temporal and frequency information.

This provides a major advantage over acoustic pipelines that reduce a recording to a small collection of summary statistics.

A simplified representation is:

$$x(t) \longrightarrow S(t, f) \longrightarrow \text{CNN representation} \longrightarrow \text{PD probability}.$$

Here, $x(t)$ represents the speech waveform and $S(t, f)$ represents its time-frequency spectrogram.

### 7.2.3 3. CNN Robustness

The CNN approach exhibited:

- high AUC;
- relatively small performance variability;
- reduced dependence on manually selected features; and
- strong performance despite low-resolution telephone recordings.

## 7.3 Future Research Directions

Table 28: Potential future research directions.

| Direction | Rationale |
|---|---|
| Explainable AI | Clinical adoption requires understanding why a model produces a prediction. |
| External Validation | Independent datasets are necessary to establish generalization. |
| Public Model Access | Public code and trained models would enable replication and benchmarking. |
| Multiple Speech Tasks | Combine sustained vowels, DDK, sentences and spontaneous speech. |
| Longitudinal Data | Enable monitoring of disease progression over time. |
| Multilingual Validation | Determine whether the approach generalizes across languages. |
| Mobile Application | Enable convenient at-home screening. |
| Clinical Trial Integration | Evaluate treatment response using repeated speech measurements. |

## 7.4 Addressing Study Limitations

Table 29: Potential solutions to the major limitations.

| Limitation | Proposed Solution |
|---|---|
| HC participants not neurologically examined | Perform neurological examination of all participants. |
| Age mismatch | Construct age-matched PD and HC cohorts. |
| CNN black-box nature | Use Grad-CAM, feature attribution and other explainability techniques. |
| Model not publicly accessible | Release source code, trained weights or an accessible demonstration system. |
| Single language | Collect and evaluate multilingual datasets. |
| Single speech task | Include multiple speech tasks. |

# 8 Ethical and Practical Considerations

## 8.1 Regulatory Pathway

A potential pathway toward clinical deployment can be summarized as follows.

Table 30: Potential pathway for clinical translation.

| Stage | Requirement |
|---|---|
| 1. Validation | Cross-validation and evaluation across multiple independent datasets. |
| 2. Clinical Trial | Prospective validation in realistic clinical environments. |
| 3. Regulatory Review | Regulatory evaluation and appropriate approval for intended diagnostic or screening use. |
| 4. Clinical Integration | Integration into clinical workflows, electronic health records and physician decision-making. |

The high AUC reported by the study should therefore be viewed as an encouraging research result rather than evidence that the system is immediately suitable for clinical diagnosis.

## 8.2 Accessibility and Equity

Remote speech analysis offers several potential benefits.

### 8.2.1 Benefits

- **Rural populations:** Screening without requiring long-distance travel.
- **Medically underserved populations:** Increased opportunity for research participation.
- **Cost:** Low-cost collection using existing telephone infrastructure.
- **Non-invasive nature:** Simple speech recording without physical intervention.

### 8.2.2 Risks

However, several risks must also be considered.

- **False positives:** May cause anxiety or unnecessary specialist referrals.
- **False negatives:** May delay diagnosis if the system is incorrectly treated as a definitive diagnostic tool.
- **Access requirements:** Telephone or smartphone access is still necessary.
- **Demographic bias:** Models trained on narrow populations may not generalize to other demographic groups.

## 8.3 Clinical Integration

Table 31: Requirements for potential clinical integration.

| Requirement | Description |
|---|---|
| Physician Oversight | The model should function as a screening or decision-support tool rather than an autonomous diagnostic system. |
| Interpretability | Clinicians should be able to understand important aspects of model predictions. |
| Validation | Prospective clinical validation is required. |
| Integration | The system should fit naturally into existing clinical workflows. |
| Training | Healthcare professionals should understand the model's capabilities and limitations. |

# 9 Conclusion

## 9.1 Summary of Key Findings

The literature reviewed demonstrates several important findings.

1. **Telephone recordings can contain useful diagnostic information:**

   Despite their low 8 kHz sampling rate and uncontrolled recording environment, telephone recordings achieved an AUC of 0.97 when analyzed using CNN transfer learning.

2. **CNN transfer learning substantially outperforms traditional approaches:**

   The Inception V3 model achieved an AUC of 0.97 compared with 0.68 for Random Forest and 0.58 for logistic regression.

3. **Color and grayscale spectrograms perform similarly:**

   Color spectrograms achieved an AUC of 0.97 while grayscale spectrograms achieved 0.96.

4. **Remote monitoring is feasible:**

   Telephone-based speech collection provides a potentially scalable method for reaching rural and medically underserved populations.

5. **Earlier diagnosis may be possible:**

   Automated analysis may identify subtle acoustic patterns that are difficult to detect through ordinary human listening.

## 9.2 Contributions to the Field

Table 32: Major contributions of the study.

| **Contribution** | **Significance** |
|---|---|
| Novel CNN Application | Application of Inception V3 transfer learning to telephone-based PD voice recordings. |
| Recording-Quality Robustness | Demonstrates the feasibility of using low-resolution 8 kHz recordings. |
| Remote Collection Viability | Supports voice collection from rural and medically underserved populations. |
| Performance Benchmark | Reports a high AUC of 0.97 for telephone-based PD classification. |

## 9.3 Final Remarks

This study demonstrates that telephone-collected voice samples can contain sufficient information for machine-learning-based Parkinson's disease detection.

The combination of spectrogram representations and CNN transfer learning achieved an AUC of 0.97, substantially outperforming conventional acoustic-feature-based methods.

The most important methodological insight is that the CNN does not require explicit manual identification of every relevant acoustic feature. Instead, the spectrogram provides a time-frequency representation from which the pretrained CNN can learn discriminative patterns.

The overall processing pipeline can therefore be summarized as:

Telephone Voice → Preprocessing → Spectrogram → Inception V3 → PD Classification

The study is particularly significant because it demonstrates high reported performance despite the use of low-resolution telephone recordings. This supports the possibility of scalable and remote voice-based screening.

Nevertheless, several challenges remain, including:

- age mismatch between PD and HC participants;
- lack of neurological examination of HC participants;
- limited interpretability of CNN predictions;
- lack of public model accessibility;
- limited language and population diversity; and
- absence of large-scale prospective clinical validation.

Therefore, the reported AUC of 0.97 should be interpreted as a strong research result rather than definitive evidence of clinical readiness.

Future work should focus on explainable AI, external validation, multilingual datasets, multiple speech tasks, longitudinal monitoring, mobile deployment and prospective clinical trials.

If these challenges can be addressed, telephone-based speech analysis could provide a scalable, inexpensive and non-invasive approach for PD screening and longitudinal monitoring, particularly for populations that have limited access to specialized neurological care.

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